

Meaning in Context - Study Guide

Use nearby evidence to determine what a word or phrase means in this specific passage.

Learning goal

Determine the intended meaning of unfamiliar, multiple-meaning, or flexible words and phrases from the sentence and surrounding context.

What this skill really means

Context meaning is not a vocabulary-memory contest. A familiar word can have several meanings, and the passage decides which meaning fits.

The strongest clue may be in the same sentence, a nearby example, a contrast, a cause-and-effect relationship, or the way the word is used across a paragraph.

Clue type	What it looks like	How it helps
Definition or restatement	The writer explains the idea in different words.	Use the explanation as a direct clue.
Example	Specific cases follow the word.	Find the meaning shared by the examples.
Contrast	but, unlike, instead, however	The opposite idea helps narrow the meaning.
Cause/effect	The sentence shows what the word causes or results from.	Infer meaning from the relationship.

How exam-style questions ask it

- What does ___ most nearly mean as used in paragraph 3?
- What does the phrase ___ suggest in the passage?
- Which meaning of ___ best fits the sentence?

A reliable method

1. Read the entire sentence before looking at the options.
2. Replace the target word with a simple phrase that would make sense there.
3. Check one or two surrounding sentences for confirmation.
4. Choose the option that fits both meaning and grammar.
5. Reject a familiar dictionary meaning if it does not fit this context.

Tips and shortcuts

- Use substitution: put each answer into the sentence and listen for meaning, not just grammar.
- Do not stop at a word you recognize. Ask which sense of the word the passage is using.
- For a phrase, interpret the whole phrase before defining individual words.

Worked examples

Example 1

The repair crew called the first estimate rough because it was based on a quick inspection and did not include the cost of hidden damage.

1. What does rough most nearly mean here?

- A. uneven to touch
- B. approximate
- C. violent
- D. difficult to hear

Answer: B

The explanation says the estimate was made quickly and was incomplete, so rough means approximate rather than physically uneven.

Example 2

After the pilot program, the manager said the new schedule had opened the door to other flexible-work options.

2. What does opened the door suggest?

- A. caused a building entrance to unlock
- B. ended every scheduling rule
- C. created an opportunity
- D. forced employees to leave

Answer: C

The phrase refers to creating a new possibility, not to a literal door.

Common traps

- A common definition that is wrong in this sentence.

- A word with the right part of speech but the wrong sense.
- A literal reading when the phrase is being used nonliterally.
- An answer that fits one word but conflicts with the surrounding idea.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, point to the exact word, phrase, or surrounding detail that proves your interpretation. If you cannot point to evidence, recheck the choice.

Quick check

1. Find the context meaning of yield: "The new filter may yield cleaner water after repeated use."
2. Explain what on the table means: "Several repair options are still on the table."
3. Why can the most common dictionary definition be a trap?

Quick check guidance

Say your answer in plain language and explain which exact wording in the sentence or passage supports it. The goal is evidence-based interpretation, not memorizing labels.